

a tear or two after the final game, a 0-1 loss to Syria, but the nightmare had just begun. The team lost 1-2 to Afghanistan, a side ranked 41 spots below India — another first on home soil.

A draw with Kuwait at home followed by a loss to Qatar, marred by controversy, ended India's flickering hopes of securing a spot in the third round of the FIFA World Cup 2026 qualifiers for the first time.

In 2023, India had won the Tri-Nations tournament, the Intercontinental Cup, and the SAFF Championship, eventually rising into the top 100 of the FIFA rankings after five years.

But 2024 felt like reading *Norwegian Wood* just after *The Alchemist* — a sense of perpetual gloom devoid of any hope of light. Upsets in Indian football were not an aberration. They were the norm.

The draw with Kuwait also brought the curtains down on the illustrious career of Chhetri, one of India's greatest-ever footballers with the highest number of goals from the country.

Within weeks, Igor Stimac, the head coach, was shown the door, and Manolo Marquez, the Spanish coach who guided Hyderabad FC to the Indian Super League title in 2022, took over.

Though results continued to be poor, glimpses of hope arrived from new players like Jithin MS, Edmund Lalrindika, Irfan Yadwad, David Lalhlansanga, Vibin Mohanan, and a resurgent Farukh Choudhary.

Farukh made his national team comeback after 1,099 days and scored on his return, a crucial equaliser against Vietnam in Marquez's first away match in charge.

In a post-Chhetri era, what awaits India in 2025 are the Asian Cup qualifiers starting in March, with the most important match being against Hong Kong, China.

Hong Kong is coached by Ashley



Inevitable: Igor Stimac lost his job as coach of the Indian men's football team, replaced by Manolo Marquez.

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Westwood, who knows Indian footballers well and guided a depleted Afghan side to triumph over India last year.

Drawn with Hong Kong, Bangladesh, and Singapore, India will

need to finish as group-toppers in the third qualifying round to seal a spot in the next edition of the continental tournament in Saudi Arabia.

There were changes in women's football too, with Santosh Kashyap succeeding Langam Chaoba Devi as the full-time head coach.

Under the former Aizawl and Salgaocar FC head coach, the Blue Tigresses reached the semifinals of the SAFF Women's Championship but lost 2-4 on penalties to host Nepal.

In December, Joakim Alexandersson — another Swede after Thomas Dennerby — joined the hierarchy of women's team coaches. While he currently manages the under-20 and under-17 sides, he will be a potential candidate to take over from Kashyap in 2025.

European top-flight

Dubbed as the 'toughest league in Europe', the usual script played out in England, where Manchester City reigned supreme and successfully defended the Premier League title.

In doing so, it became the first side to win four titles on the trot. While the club received plaudits for this unprecedented feat, it also garnered attention for all the wrong reasons due to the 115 charges of Premier League rule breaches, a major talking point in the footballing world.

According to the latest reports, the hearing for all the charges has concluded, and the number has risen to 130. The verdict is expected sometime in 2025, though no exact timeline has been conveyed.

Real Madrid grabbed the honours in Spanish top-flight football. Carlo Ancelotti's men cemented their authority and won La Liga with 95 points — 10 more than arch-rival Barcelona, which endured a tumultuous season owing to financial difficulties and changes in the dugout.

Germany saw the rise of a new